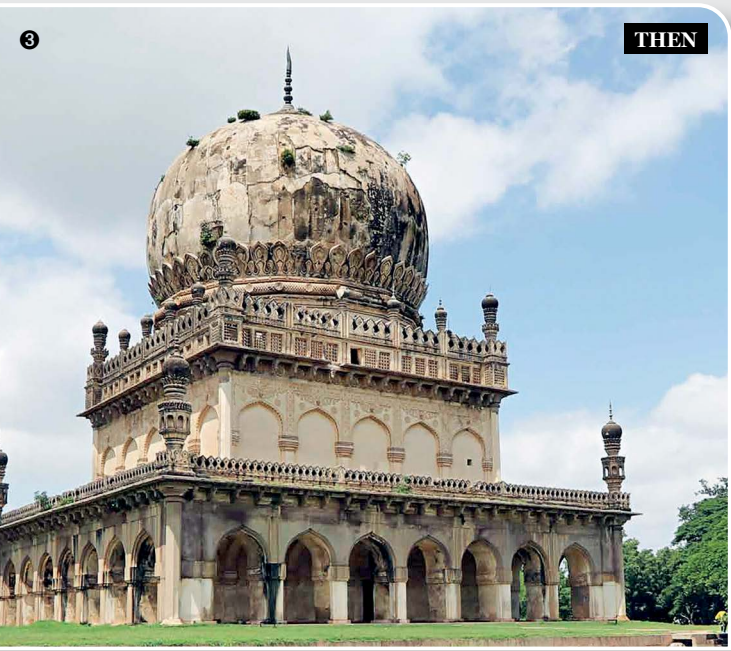
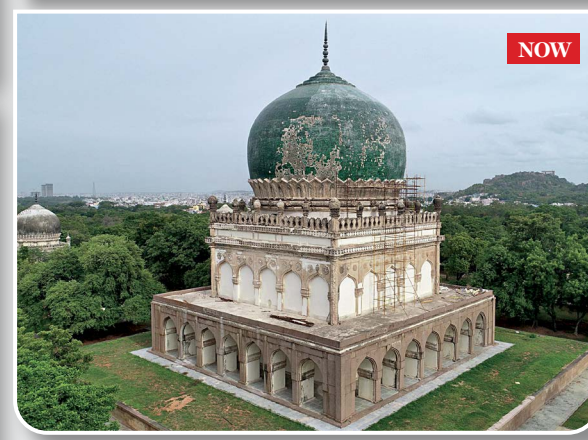








Return of the Gilded Domes

1. The mausoleum of Quli Qutb Shah and surrounding gardens seen soon after the conservation process started (top) and fully restored now **2.** A master craftsman unearthing, and then restoring, an ornate stucco work inside the tomb of Abdullah Qutb Shah's mausoleum **3.** The mausoleum of Abdullah Qutb Shah, its dome once battered and disfigured, is restored fully **4.** The blackened dome of the mausoleum of Muhammad Qutb Shah (top), which was restored using new green glazed tiles

Photographs courtesy: **GOVERNMENT OF TELANGANA/AKTC**

Several entities, including the Union and state governments, have co-funded the unique public-private conservation and restoration project executed by the AKTC. With around 100 monuments and structures painstakingly restored and 106 acres carefully landscaped, QSHP is the largest conservation project India has ever seen.

"The intricate conservation process is based on documentation, archival research, defining statement of significance, a crafts-led approach through use of traditional materials and building techniques, high level of supervision and peer review of conservation plan and efforts," says AKTC CEO Ratish Nanda.

Conserving the heritage park threw up unique tasks. The first was to conduct a global archival research programme that has so far uncovered over 500 images of the complex from the 1850s onwards. Another task was to carry out an architectural documentation and assessing conditions, including through ground-penetrating radar surveys. Drawing from the AKTC's experience with the Humayun's Tomb heritage site in Delhi, a similar craft-based approach was executed at QSHP. Since 2013, stone-carvers, masons, glazed tile-makers, coppersmiths and gardeners—their skills handed down the generations—have matched the craftsmanship of their forefathers.